Parallel Connected Components

MPI + OpenCilk Hybrid Implementation

Parallel and Distributed Computing

Evangelos Moschou & Elena Paricio (Erasmus student)
AEM: 10986

December 18, 2025

Abstract

This report presents a hybrid MPI+OpenCilk parallel algorithm for computing connected components in large sparse graphs. We describe the algorithm, key optimizations (asynchronous communication, edge-balanced partitioning), and present performance results showing 2.5x speedup with asynchronous BFS.

1 Introduction

Finding connected components in large graphs is a fundamental problem in graph analytics with applications in social network analysis, image processing, and scientific computing. As graph sizes grow to billions of edges, parallel algorithms become essential for practical computation times.

This project implements a parallel connected components algorithm using:

- **MPI** (Message Passing Interface) for distributed memory parallelism across cluster nodes.
- **OpenCilk** for shared memory parallelism within each node using work-stealing.

The input graphs are stored in MATLAB's `.mat` format and converted to Compressed Sparse Row (CSR) format for efficient traversal.

2 Algorithm Design

2.1 Graph Representation

The input graph is stored using the Compressed Sparse Row (CSR) format, consisting of the arrays `row_ptr[n+1]` and `col_idx[m]`, where `row_ptr` defines the adjacency list boundaries and `col_idx` stores destination vertices. This representation provides $O(1)$ neighbor access, good cache locality, and is well suited for large sparse graphs. CSR is also convenient for distributed memory, since vertex ranges can be cleanly partitioned across MPI ranks while keeping adjacency lists contiguous in memory.

2.2 Label Propagation Algorithm

Connected components are computed using an iterative label propagation approach. Initially, each vertex is assigned its own global ID as a label. At each iteration, vertices propagate the minimum label among their neighbors, and the process repeats until no labels change. This algorithm is simple, scalable, and works well on large real-world graphs. Convergence is guaranteed when a global iteration completes with no further label updates.

2.3 Parallelization Strategy

MPI-based graph partitioning. The graph is distributed across MPI ranks by assigning each process a contiguous range of global vertices $[vtx_dist[rank], vtx_dist[rank+1])$. This distribution is computed during initialization using a block-based (edge-aware) partitioning strategy implemented in `partition.c`. During execution, ownership of a global vertex is determined using the `get_owner()` function, which performs a binary search on the `vtx_dist` array (see `BFSmpi.c`). This allows each rank to distinguish between local and remote vertices efficiently.

Local computation with OpenCilk. Within each MPI rank, shared-memory parallelism is exploited using OpenCilk. Vertex processing loops are parallelized with `cilk_for`, allowing efficient load balancing via work-stealing. This hybrid MPI + OpenCilk model enables parallelism both across nodes (distributed memory) and within nodes (shared memory).

Inter-rank communication. Since MPI ranks do not share memory, label updates involving remote vertices must be explicitly communicated. When a rank encounters an edge whose destination vertex belongs to another rank, the update is packed into a send buffer. Communication follows a standard MPI two-phase pattern: `MPI_Alltoall` is used to exchange message sizes, and `MPI_Alltoallv` is then used to exchange the actual variable-sized buffers containing pairs of (vertex, label). This explicit message passing is a fundamental difference from the shared-memory approach used in HW1.

Global convergence detection. Termination cannot be decided locally. In the frontier-based BFS variant, convergence is detected when the global frontier size becomes zero, computed using `MPI_Allreduce` with a SUM operation across all ranks. In the asynchronous variant, a quiescence detection mechanism is implemented by tracking globally sent and received messages and using non-blocking collective operations (`MPI_Iallreduce`) while continuing to poll for incoming updates.

3 Optimizations

3.1 Binary CSR Caching

We cache converted graphs as `.csrbin` files, reducing load times from minutes to seconds.

3.2 Graph Preprocessing

Symmetrization ensures undirected graphs; **degree-based reordering** improves cache locality.

3.3 Edge-Balanced Partitioning

Instead of simple vertex-block distribution, we balance edges per MPI rank, significantly improving load balance for scale-free graphs.

3.4 Asynchronous BFS

Our asynchronous variant overlaps computation with communication using double-buffered `MPI_Isend`, polls for messages during local propagation, and uses quiescence-based termination. This achieves **2.5x speedup** over synchronous.

3.5 64-bit Indexing

To support graphs with >2.14B edges, we use 64-bit `long long` for edge counts and row pointers.

4 Implementation

The project uses a Makefile with automatic detection of local OpenCilk and Matio library. SLURM scripts handle module loading and environment setup. Build artifacts are isolated per-test to prevent race conditions during parallel job submission.

5 Results

5.1 Test Environment

Experiments were conducted on the AUTH HPC cluster "Rome" partition (AMD EPYC, Rocky Linux 9, GCC 13.2.0, OpenMPI 5.0.3, 2 nodes, 4 tasks per node).

5.2 Benchmark Dataset

`mawi_201512020330.mat` from the SuiteSparse Matrix Collection:

- **Vertices**: 226,196,185
- **Edges**: 480,047,894
- **Connected Components**: 3,971,144

5.3 Mawi Benchmark Results

Test	Nodes	Procs	Algorithm	Time (s)	Speedup
test5	1	1	Sync (Sequential)	7.56	1.00×
test1	1	1	Sync (10 Workers)	4.65	1.63×
test8	2	4	Async	5.87	1.29×
test9	2	8	Async	**4.82**	1.57×
test10	2	8	Sync + PGO	12.15	0.62×
test11	2	8	Async + PGO	5.63	1.34×

Table 1: Mawi Benchmark Results: mawi_201512020330 (480M edges). All configurations find 3,971,144 components. Speedup relative to sequential baseline (test5).

5.3.1 Slurm Output: Edge-Balanced Partition

```
Balanced Partition:
  Rank 0: Rows 0 - 1
  Rank 1: Rows 1 - 2
  Rank 2: Rows 2 - 3
  Rank 3: Rows 3 - 164628
  Rank 4: Rows 164628 - 46178221
  Rank 5: Rows 46178221 - 106184207
  Rank 6: Rows 106184207 - 166190193
  Rank 7: Rows 166190193 - 226196185
```

Listing 1: Edge-Balanced Distribution across 8 MPI Ranks

5.3.2 Slurm Output: Benchmark Results

```
Using Original Graph Loading (Rank 0 Central)...
Loaded: 226196185 vertices, 480047894 edges
MPI CC: procs=1 iters=11 time=7.559729 s components=3971144
```

Listing 2: Sequential Run (test5)

```
Running ASYNC version...
MPI CC: procs=8 iters=4298990 time=4.843280 s components=3971144
```

Listing 3: Async Distributed Run (test9)

```
Running ASYNC version...
MPI CC: procs=8 iters=3128528 time=5.634901 s components=3971144
```

Listing 4: Async + PGO Run (test11)

5.4 Analysis

5.4.1 Async Speedup

The asynchronous algorithm achieves **1.56x speedup** over the sequential baseline (7.56s $\rightarrow$ 4.84s) by overlapping computation with communication.

5.4.2 PGO Impact

Profile-Guided Optimization reduced iterations from 4.3M to 3.1M through better branch prediction, but the final time (5.63s) is slightly higher than the non-PGO async run (4.84s). This is attributed to cluster load conditions: the PGO tests (test10, test11) were executed on a day when the cluster was significantly more overloaded, causing all builds and runs to complete slower than usual.

5.5 Friendster Benchmark

We also evaluated the scalability on the `com-Friendster` graph, significantly larger than Mawi:

- **Vertices**: 65,608,366
- **Edges**: $\approx$ 2.5 Billion
- **Configuration**: Hybrid MPI + OpenCilk (Streaming Frontier BFS)

5.5.1 Performance Analysis on Friendster

Table 2 summarizes the performance on the Friendster graph.

Environment	Configuration	Cores	Time (s)	MTEPS
Auth HPC Cluster (Distributed MPI)				
Cluster Sequential	1 Node (1 MPI Rank)	1	74.94	48.2
Cluster Parallel	1 Node (4 MPI x 16 Cilk)	64	33.01	109.4
Cluster Parallel	2 Nodes (8 MPI x 16 Cilk)	128	**29.86**	120.9
Cluster Parallel	3 Nodes (12 MPI x 16 Cilk)	192	31.04	116.3
Local Workstation (Shared Memory OpenCilk)				
Local Parallel	1 Node (16 Cilk Workers)	16	**1.30**	**2778.6**

Table 2: Friendster Benchmark Results: Cluster (MPI) vs Local (OpenCilk)

Analysis: The local workstation (Ryzen 7 5800H, 32GB RAM, 14.5GB (peak usage)) significantly outperforms the cluster for this specific workload.

- **Local Speedup**: The shared-memory Cilk implementation (Label Propagation) running on a single consumer node completes in **1.30s**, which is **23x faster** than the best distributed run on the cluster (29.86s).
- **Overhead**: The cluster performance is dominated by the overhead of the distributed Frontier BFS algorithm (partitioning, communication, message packing) which is necessary for scaling to multi-terabyte graphs but inefficient for graphs that fit in a single node's RAM relative to a zero-overhead shared-memory approach.
- **Sequential Baseline**: The cluster sequential baseline (74.94s) highlights the significant cost of the distributed data structures even when running on a single rank, compared to the optimized local execution.

6 Conclusion

We implemented a hybrid MPI+OpenCilk parallel connected components algorithm with:

- Binary CSR caching for fast graph loading
- **Asynchronous BFS** providing 1.56x speedup over sequential
- Edge-balanced partitioning for scale-free graphs
- 64-bit indexing for billion-edge graphs

vfill **Source Code:** `https://github.com/EvangelosMoschou/PaDSProject2.git`